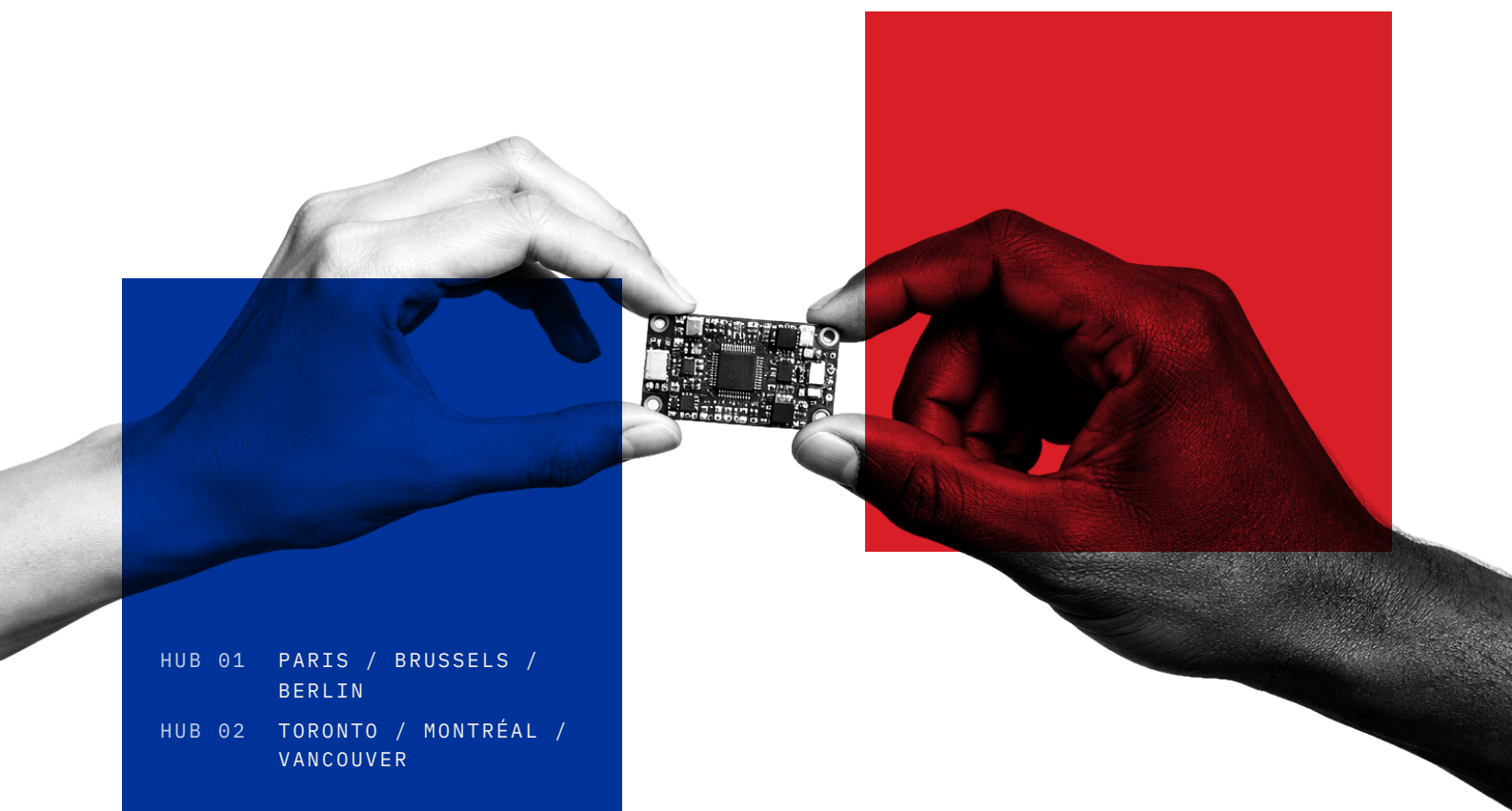




HUB 01 PARIS / BRUSSELS /
BERLIN

HUB 02 TORONTO / MONTRÉAL /
VANCOUVER

EU CAN INNOVATE

EU-Canada Digital Bridge Hackathon

PREPARED BY

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STATUS

Early-stage draft, seeking feedback
and expressions of interest

DATE

October 2026

SECTION 01

The opportunity, and the case for acting now

On September 16, 2026, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen proposed that Canada become the European Union's first associate member, with Prime Minister Mark Carney present in the chamber in Strasbourg.

The proposal points at technology, critical raw materials, energy and security. Its legal shape is still undefined, and an EU-Canada Summit in October 2026 may carry the discussion further.

We see strong political intent and mutual commitment. What we need now is a visible, working demonstration at the level where cooperation is actually built: among the engineers, founders, designers and researchers who would have to deliver it.

That foundation already exists today. Canada has been associated with Pillar II of Horizon Europe, the Union's research and innovation programme, since 2022, covering climate, energy, the digital economy and health.

A legal and funding structure for EU-Canada innovation cooperation is therefore in place. This initiative sets out to make it tangible and visible.

EU CAN Innovate brings practitioners from across the Union and from Canada into one working format, builds prototypes against real, pre-scoped problems, and documents what comes out of it.

This works, regardless of how
or whether a formal political
arrangement is ever finalised.

SECTION 02

Four focus areas

Mapped onto the sectors named in the Union's own proposal, so the work stays relevant to the political process without depending on it.

T/01

Technology

Digital innovation and shared tooling across the two research ecosystems.

T/02

Critical raw materials

Supply-chain transparency and circularity for minerals and battery inputs.

T/03

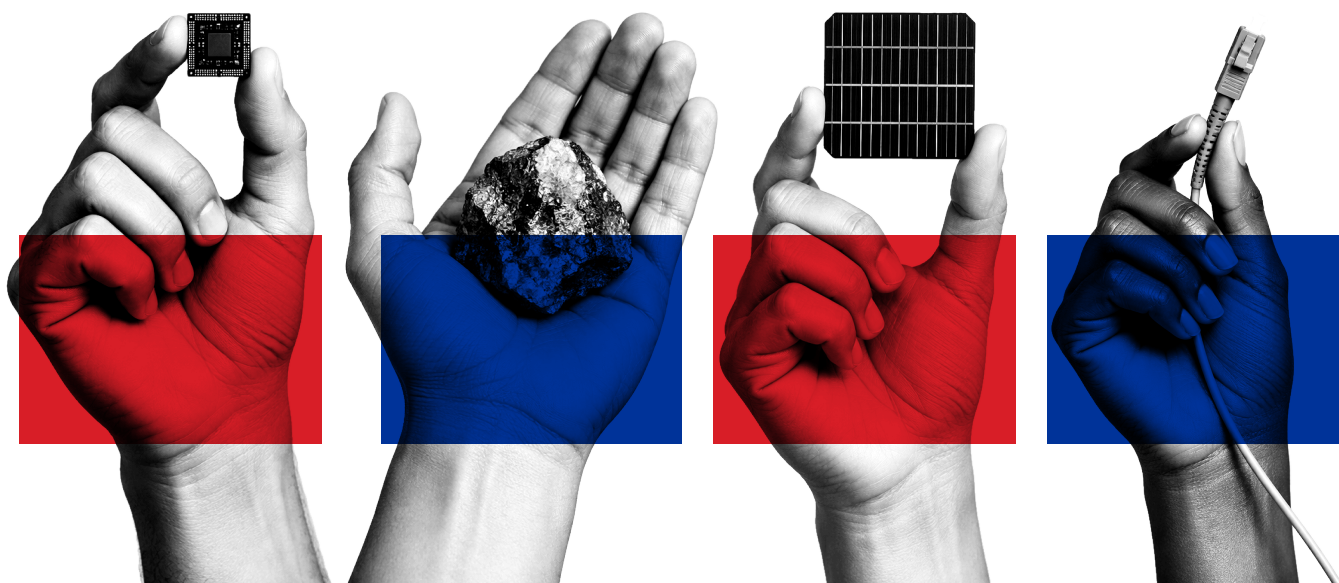
Energy

Renewables, grid integration and the transatlantic hydrogen corridor.

T/04

Resilience

Civilian infrastructure and cybersecurity (excluding defence and dual-use).



SECTION 03

Two rooms, one event

MODEL

Hybrid. One European hub (Paris, Brussels or Berlin) live-linked to one Canadian hub (Toronto, Montréal or Vancouver), both to be confirmed with partners. Open to participants from across EU member states.

DURATION

Two to three days. Open to discussion with partners.

LANGUAGE

English.

CADENCE

The first edition of a recurring, documented format, not a one-off. Outputs are meant to be citable over time.

Who we want in the room

01

Developers and engineers

From both research ecosystems.

02

Startup founders

Early-stage, building in the four tracks.

03

Designers

Product, interaction and industrial.

04

Researchers

University staff and graduate students.

05

Corporate innovation

As mentors and challenge sponsors.

06

Institutional presence

Parliament, missions or Commission, as observers.



SECTION 04

From prototype to impact

Output quality depends on the quality of the challenge behind it. Every track is scoped in advance with a real problem owner: an industry partner, a research consortium, or an organisation already working across the EU-Canada relationship. Never a generic, open-ended prompt.

01

A named challenge owner

Each track carries a genuine, unsolved problem and an organisation that owns it.

02

Teams matched in advance

Skills matched to the challenge, EU-Canada pairing built into pre-event matching rather than left to chance.

03

A committed next step

A pilot conversation, an accelerator place, or at minimum a scheduled debrief, agreed before the event.

THE AIM

A credible starting point for continued work, not a demo that ends when the room empties.

INDICATIVE EVENT FLOW

DAY 1

Kick-off

Challenge owners brief all teams live across both hubs. Matched teams meet and settle their approach.

DAY 2

Build

Teams prototype with mentors in their hub and sync across the Atlantic in the shared window.

DAY 3

Demo

Teams present to their challenge owners, who confirm the agreed next step for each track.

SECTION 05

Phases

01

Now – Dec 2026

Outreach and feedback

Share this note with potential partners, gather input, refine scope and format.

02

Early 2027

Scoping and commitments

Confirm challenge owners, secure hosting and co-organising partners, fix both host cities.

03

Mid – late 2027

First edition

The event runs across both hubs.

04

After

Documentation and follow-through

Record outcomes, follow up on challenge results, plan a second edition.

Deliberately decoupled from the EU-Canada political calendar. The pace is set to produce a solid first edition, not to chase a negotiation milestone.

SECTION 06

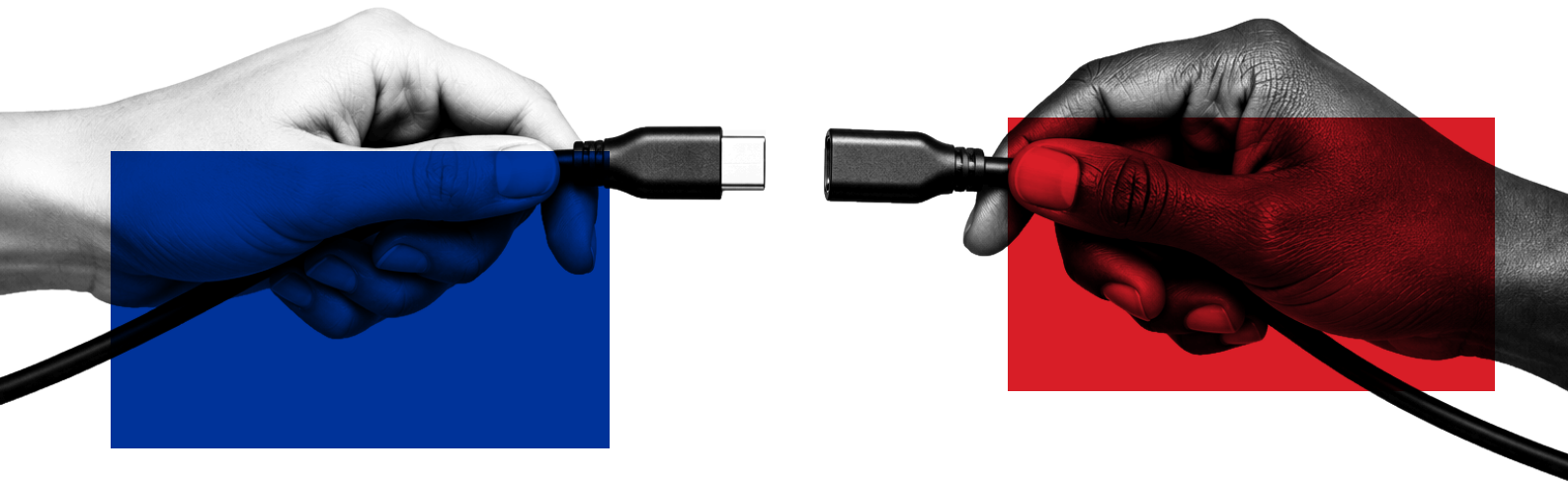
Who we are looking to engage

Rather than naming individual organisations at this stage, the initiative is seeking conversations across these categories. Specific approaches are being made directly and separately.

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- | | |
|---|---|
| A | Bilateral chambers of commerce and trade associations active in EU-Canada relations |
|---|---|
-
- | | |
|---|--|
| B | Cleantech and innovation accelerator networks in the EU and Canada |
|---|--|
-
- | | |
|---|--|
| C | Public funding and research bodies connected to Horizon Europe or equivalent Canadian programmes |
|---|--|
-
- | | |
|---|--|
| D | Universities and research institutions with relevant technical expertise |
|---|--|
-
- | | |
|---|--|
| E | Diplomatic missions and EU institutions, as observers or supporters rather than organisers |
|---|--|
-

Four questions for you

- | | |
|--|--|
| 01 Does this fill a gap, or overlap with something you already run? | 02 A standalone hackathon, a track inside an existing event, or another model? |
| 03 What timing realistically fits the pace of the political process? | 04 Which of the four tracks matters most to your stakeholders? |



LET US TALK

ABOUT THE INITIATOR

An independent initiative led by Krishen Mertens, a Berlin-based design and innovation professional working at the intersection of technology and sustainability. Not undertaken on behalf of, or with the backing of, any employer.

PURPOSE OF THIS DOCUMENT

An early-stage concept note, not a finalised event proposal. It exists to test whether the idea resonates, to gather honest feedback on scope and feasibility, and to identify co-organisers, hosts and challenge partners.

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